



It is a charged moment in the world economy, and India stands right at the heart of it. As the global trade order rewires and nations rethink their economic alliances, India's commerce and trade policy has never been more consequential. At this high-stakes moment, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal joined BT at the India@100 event to help decode the new trade order and India's strategic playbook for navigating it. Edited excerpts from an exclusive conversation with Siddharth Zarabi and Gaurav Sawant:

SZ: At a time when global investors are very keenly looking at India, how are we shaping our engagement with the world?

A: The world keeps evolving, international trade keeps finding new pathways. What we are seeing today is possibly just a churn that happens every few years. Every few years, new countries come up, some countries go down. This is part of the history of nations. I think this is India's time (*Yeh Bharat ka samay hai*). What I can see right before my eyes is how Prime Minister Narendra Modi inspired the whole nation, how he raised the nation's morale, how he called upon the nation—this country will not bow; it will not kneel before anyone. Now, whether it's our farmers, our livestock breeders, our retail traders, our small industries, entrepreneurs linked to micro or small units—the government takes care of their interests; we handle the nation's affairs with public interest and national interest as the priority. India will have a place in this new world order.

GS: PM Modi often says he turns every stone thrown at him into a stepping stone. What

are the stones being thrown at India right now and where do you see the opportunity in adversity?

A: I don't see stones being thrown at us. India's morale and capabilities are strong. Take Y2K in 1999: the world feared a crash, but (then PM) Atal Bihari Vajpayee's government saw opportunity. By supporting the information technology sector through software technology parks, a new telecommunications policy, and minimal interference, India built a \$300 billion industry that employs millions.

During Covid-19, many predicted starvation and vaccine failure. Rich nations hoarded vaccines, but India developed and produced its own, administering 2.5 billion doses and giving free vaccines to over 100 countries. Not one person died of starvation—800 million people received rations; farmers, railways, power, and coal kept running under strict protocols.

In both crises, India turned adversity into strength, emerging, as I say, like *Sita Maiya* from *agni pariksha* (a trial by fire), and came out a winner.

SZ: How can India navigate de-globalisation and the way the trade order is being dismantled? What do you think the playbook will be?

A: I don't see any de-globalisation. I see countries restructuring their trade routes and partners. I'm quite confident that India's exports in the current year will be more than what they were last year.

“The world recognises India's strengths, recognises our demographic advantages, and what 1.4 billion aspirational Indians bring to the table in terms of demand”

SZ: How would you describe the state of India's economy, particularly because someone recently called it a 'dead economy'?

A: I think that was very sad. The whole world is looking up to India. The world recognises us as the fastest-growing large economy. We are contributing 16% of global growth. Our inflation is among the lowest